

Employee Handbook

HR Policies & Procedures Manual

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1. Leave and Time-Off Policy

This section describes all categories of paid and unpaid leave available to employees. All leave requests must be submitted through the HR portal unless otherwise noted.

1.1 Annual Leave

Employees are entitled to 20 working days of paid annual leave per calendar year, accrued monthly at a rate of approximately 1.67 days per month. Leave requests must be submitted at least 5 business days in advance and approved by the employee's direct manager. Unused annual leave may be carried over up to a maximum of 5 days into the following calendar year.

1.2 Sick Leave

Employees may take up to 10 paid sick days per calendar year. Absences longer than 3 consecutive calendar days require a medical certificate submitted to HR within 5 business days of returning to work.

1.3 Public Holidays

Employees are entitled to all officially recognized public holidays in their country of employment, in addition to their annual leave entitlement.

1.4 Menstrual Leave

Female employees are entitled to up to 3 paid menstrual leave days per month. This leave may be taken on a self-declared basis and does not require a medical certificate. Menstrual leave days are non-cumulative and do not carry over between months. Requests may be submitted on the same day they are needed, without advance notice.

1.5 Paternity Leave

Employees who become fathers are entitled to 1 year (12 months) of job-protected paternity leave, beginning on the date of the child's birth or legal adoption. The first 8 weeks of paternity leave are paid at 100% of the employee's base salary. The remaining period may be taken as unpaid leave, with the guarantee of returning to an equivalent role, level, and compensation at any point during or at the end of the leave period.

1.6 Birthday Leave

All employees receive one additional paid day off on their birthday. If the birthday falls on a weekend or public holiday, the day off may be taken on the nearest working day, subject to manager approval.

1.7 Pet Care Leave

Employees who own a pet are entitled to 2 additional paid leave days per month to support pet-related needs such as veterinary appointments, emergencies, or the adoption of a new pet.

Employees may choose to take these as full days off, or convert them into additional remote work days at their discretion, subject to manager notification.

1.8 How to Request Leave

All leave categories above follow the same request process, unless otherwise specified:

- Submit a leave request through the HR portal, selecting the applicable leave category.
- Requests are routed automatically to the employee's direct manager for approval.
- Approved leave is reflected in the shared team calendar within 1 business day.
- For leave categories requiring no advance notice (e.g. menstrual leave, sick leave), employees should notify their manager as early as possible on the day of absence.

2. Remote & Hybrid Work Policy

This policy applies to all employees in roles eligible for remote or hybrid work arrangements, as designated by their department.

2.1 Work Location & Schedule

Eligible employees follow a hybrid schedule, working from the office a minimum of 2 days per week, with the remaining days worked remotely. Specific in-office days are agreed upon with the employee's team and manager.

2.2 Core Working Hours

All employees, regardless of location, must be available during core working hours of 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM local time to support team collaboration and meetings.

2.3 Equipment & Home Office Stipend

The company provides the following to support remote work:

- A company laptop and standard peripherals (mouse, keyboard, headset).
- A one-time home office setup stipend of \$500, claimable within the first 3 months of employment.
- A monthly internet/utilities allowance as defined in the employee's compensation package.

2.4 Data Security

Employees working remotely must use company-issued devices with full-disk encryption and up-to-date security software, connect via the company VPN when accessing internal systems, and avoid conducting work on unsecured public networks without VPN protection.

3. Expense & Travel Policy

This policy governs the reimbursement of business-related expenses and travel arrangements.

3.1 Reimbursement Process

Expenses must be submitted through the expense management portal within 30 days of being incurred, accompanied by an itemized receipt. Expenses submitted after 30 days may be declined at management's discretion.

3.2 Approval Thresholds

Expense approval follows a tiered process based on amount:

- Under \$200: automatically approved upon manager sign-off.
- \$200–\$1,000: requires direct manager approval.
- Over \$1,000: requires both direct manager and department head approval.

3.3 Business Travel

Business travel must be booked at least 7 business days in advance through the approved corporate travel portal. Economy class is standard for flights under 6 hours; business class may be approved for longer flights with department head sign-off. A daily meal per diem of \$60 applies for domestic travel and \$90 for international travel.

4. Recruitment & Hiring Process

This section outlines the standard hiring process followed for all open positions.

4.1 Interview Stages

Candidates typically progress through the following stages:

- Application screening by the Talent Acquisition team.
- Initial phone/video screening (30 minutes) with a recruiter.
- Technical or role-specific panel interview (60–90 minutes).
- Final interview with the hiring manager and/or department head.

4.2 Reference Checks

A minimum of 2 professional references must be checked prior to extending an offer. References are contacted only after the candidate has reached the final interview stage and given explicit consent.

4.3 Offer & Onboarding

Offers require approval from the hiring manager, department head, and HR before being extended. All new hires complete a 90-day probationary period, during which performance and fit are formally reviewed at the 30, 60, and 90-day marks.

5. Performance Review Policy

Performance reviews are conducted twice per year to support employee growth and fair compensation decisions.

5.1 Review Cycle

Formal performance reviews take place twice annually, in June and December. Employees complete a self-assessment, which is reviewed alongside manager feedback and, where applicable, 360-degree peer feedback.

5.2 Evaluation Criteria

Reviews assess performance across three main dimensions:

- Goal achievement against objectives set at the start of the review period.
- Core competencies relevant to the employee's role and level.
- Collaboration and peer feedback, gathered through a 360-degree review process.

5.3 Ratings & Promotions

Employees are rated on a 5-point scale ranging from 'Does Not Meet Expectations' to 'Outstanding'. Promotion and compensation adjustments are reviewed following the December cycle and take effect the following January.

6. Code of Conduct & Disciplinary Policy

All employees are expected to act with integrity, respect, and professionalism at all times.

6.1 Expected Conduct

Employees must treat colleagues, clients, and partners with respect, avoid conflicts of interest, and comply with all applicable laws and company policies, including the company's anti-harassment and anti-discrimination policy.

6.2 Reporting Violations

Suspected violations of the Code of Conduct may be reported confidentially through the Ethics Hotline or directly to HR. Reports are investigated promptly, and retaliation against employees who report in good faith is strictly prohibited.

6.3 Disciplinary Process

Disciplinary action follows a progressive process, except in cases of serious misconduct which may result in immediate termination:

- Verbal warning, documented in the employee's file.
- Written warning, with a defined improvement plan.
- Final written warning.
- Termination of employment.

All disciplinary steps are handled confidentially and in coordination with HR to ensure a fair and consistent process.